The Space Between Our Classes

An alternate universe story about university, growing up, and the person who slowly becomes part of your everyday life.

A story of Dia and Alka

“Some people don't change your life all at once. They become part of it quietly.”

1. A Question About Wi-Fi

The first time Alka spoke to Dia, she was annoyed.

Not with Dia, specifically. With the university Wi-Fi, which had stopped working halfway through an online quiz, and with the fact that the biotechnology department's technical support number had apparently been disconnected since the previous academic year.

Dia was sitting on the floor outside a computer laboratory, laptop balanced on her knees, trying to figure out why a virtual machine kept refusing to cooperate.

“Do you know anything about networks?” Alka asked.

Dia looked up. “Unfortunately.”

“Our department's Wi-Fi keeps disconnecting. The IT guy said something about the server, but he said it in a way that made me think he wanted me to stop asking questions.”

“That's a surprisingly common technical support strategy.”

Alka laughed, though she looked too irritated to find anything particularly funny.

Dia helped her check a few settings. It turned out the problem wasn't something Alka could fix herself, but Dia explained what was probably happening and gave her the right support contact.

“You're studying computer science?” Alka asked.

“Cybersecurity.”

“Oh. So you know how to hack things?”

“No.”

Alka looked disappointed. “That's what everyone says.”

“Because most of us are trying to get our assignments submitted before midnight, not break into the university database.”

“Fair enough.”

Alka introduced herself, thanked Dia, and left.

Dia returned to her virtual machine.

Five minutes later, she realised Alka had forgotten her water bottle.

She picked it up, looked down the corridor, and saw Alka disappearing around the stairs. Dia considered keeping it until their next encounter. Then she remembered that she, too, had once forgotten something in a classroom and spent an entire afternoon searching for it.

She sent a message through the university student group.

Someone left a bottle outside Lab 3. Biotechnology department, maybe?

A few minutes later, Alka replied.

Mine. Please don't drink from it.

Dia typed back:

I was planning to sell it.

That was their second conversation.

Neither thought much of it.

2. Two Different Ways of Looking at Things

For the first few weeks, they knew each other mostly by department.

Alka was the biotechnology student who occasionally asked Dia computer-related questions. Dia was the cybersecurity student who occasionally complained about the cafeteria's coffee.

They saw each other near the vending machines, outside lecture halls, and at the bus stop where half the university seemed to gather at the end of the day.

Sometimes they talked. Sometimes they only waved.

Then the university introduced a shared elective on research ethics and data privacy.

Alka arrived on the first day carrying a notebook covered in small, handwritten diagrams. Dia arrived with a laptop and the expression of someone who had read the syllabus and already identified three unnecessary assignments.

They sat together because the seats around them were full.

Their first discussion was about genetic data.

Alka argued that biological information could reveal things about a person that even they might not know yet. Dia pointed out that collecting such information without adequate safeguards could turn a medical database into a privacy disaster.

“You always look at what's going to go wrong,” Alka said afterward.

“It's literally my subject.”

“I know. But don't you ever think about what could go right?”

Dia considered this.

“Of course. That's why I want the systems to work.”

Alka smiled. “See? You do have a positive side.”

“Don't tell anyone.”

Their conversations began to stretch beyond the classroom.

Alka explained why certain experiments required weeks of waiting for results, and Dia explained why fixing a vulnerability wasn't always as simple as finding it.

They discovered that their subjects were different, but their frustrations were remarkably similar. Both involved long hours of work whose most important parts were often invisible to everyone else.

“That's a surprisingly common technical support strategy,” became one of their recurring jokes; so did Alka's insistence that Dia needed to remain within her area of expertise.

Dia began looking forward to Alka's dry humour. Alka began saving her strangest questions for Dia.

Neither announced that they were becoming friends. They simply kept talking.

3. The Two Boys

Nikhil was in Dia's cybersecurity cohort. He was competent, slightly impatient, and the sort of person who could spend an hour explaining why a project was badly designed but become strangely silent when asked to suggest a better one.

He and Dia worked together occasionally. Their friendship consisted mostly of exchanging notes, arguing about code, and sending each other screenshots of bugs with captions that became increasingly dramatic as deadlines approached.

Once, he asked Dia whether she wanted to join him and a few others for lunch.

She said she was waiting for someone.

“Who?”

“Alka.”

Nikhil looked at her. “The biotechnology girl?”

“Yes, Nikhil. There is only one Alka in this conversation.”

He raised his hands. “Okay. I'm just surprised you have friends outside the department.”

Dia threw a tissue at him.

The other boy, Luca, was in Alka's laboratory group. He was good at making complicated things sound manageable, though he had a tendency to volunteer for responsibilities and then regret them immediately.

He and Alka got along well, partly because she was patient enough to listen to him complain about lab reports without taking the complaints too seriously.

When the four of them eventually ate together, nobody announced that a new friendship group had formed.

Nikhil and Luca discussed an upcoming university event. Alka complained about a practical assessment. Dia corrected something Nikhil said about encryption. Luca asked whether cybersecurity

students actually spent all day hacking.

Dia stared at him.

Alka started laughing.

“Please don't,” Dia said.

“What? It's a genuine question.”

“It's a genuine question that I've answered seventeen times this month.”

Luca apologised, then immediately asked whether Dia could help him recover a file he'd accidentally deleted.

She agreed to take a look.

The boys became familiar faces, sometimes joining the girls for coffee or walking with them after class. There was no fixed group, no obligation to include everyone in everything.

Some days, it was the four of them. Some days, it was just Dia and Alka. And some days, everyone was too busy to talk at all.

That felt more like real friendship than any arrangement they could have made.

4. A Bad Week, Not a Tragedy

The middle of the semester arrived with the usual collection of deadlines.

Alka had laboratory work that required her to repeat an experiment after an unexpected result. She had already spent hours preparing, and the thought of doing everything again made her want to put her notebook away and refuse to look at it for a week.

Dia was dealing with a different kind of frustration. A project she had spent several evenings working on kept failing under conditions that made no sense to her.

For several days, their conversations became shorter.

How was your day?

Long.

Same.

Did you eat?

Yes.

Liar.

On Thursday, Dia found Alka sitting outside a laboratory with her notebook closed beside her.

“You're here early,” Dia said.

“So are you.”

“My lab session got cancelled.”

“My experiment failed.”

“Again?”

“Again.”

There was a pause.

Then Dia said, “That sounds expensive.”

Alka looked at her. “Emotionally or financially?”

“Both, probably.”

Alka laughed, then leaned back against the wall.

For a while, they talked about their respective problems. They complained about supervisors, deadlines, equipment, and the general unfairness of having to do difficult things when they were already tired.

At one point, Alka said, “Sometimes I think everyone else knows what they're doing.”

Dia shook her head. “Most people are just better at looking like they know.”

“Is that what you're doing?”

“Absolutely.”

Alka smiled.

The conversation drifted elsewhere. They talked about food, a film neither had finished watching, and whether the university should be legally prohibited from scheduling assessments on consecutive days.

By the time Alka's next class approached, neither problem had been solved. But when they stood up, Alka seemed less defeated.

“Thanks for sitting with me,” she said.

Dia shrugged. “I was already sitting.”

Alka rolled her eyes. “You're impossible.”

“You're welcome.”

Later that evening, Dia received a photograph of Alka's laboratory notebook.

Attempt number three. Pray for me.

Dia replied:

May your cells cooperate and your supervisor develop empathy.

Alka sent back a laughing voice note.

Dia listened to it twice.

Not because anything remarkable had been said.

Because it was nice to hear her laugh.

5. What Friendship Looked Like From the Outside

By the following semester, people had started assuming that Dia and Alka knew where to find each other.

If Alka wanted to borrow a charger, someone suggested Dia. If Dia wanted to know whether the campus café was crowded, someone suggested asking Alka.

They had become familiar parts of each other's routines without ever deciding to become that.

Alka knew that Dia disliked being interrupted when she was concentrating, but that she could talk endlessly once she had finished her work. Dia knew that Alka often said she was fine before she had actually decided whether she was.

Alka knew that Dia preferred having a problem explained logically before being offered reassurance. Dia knew that sometimes Alka didn't want solutions at all. She simply wanted to complain about something without hearing that it would eventually work out.

They weren't always right about each other.

Once, Dia tried to solve a problem Alka had only wanted to talk about. Alka told her so. Dia apologised.

Another time, Alka assumed Dia was upset with her because Dia had been unusually quiet. Dia explained that she was simply exhausted.

They learned. Not perfectly. Not all at once. Just enough to make the next misunderstanding a little easier to handle.

And perhaps that was the most intimate part of their friendship: the gradual accumulation of small corrections.

Learning when to ask. Learning when to leave a person alone. Learning that knowing someone well didn't mean you could read their mind.

One afternoon, Nikhil watched Dia and Alka argue over whether they should order food or walk to the cafeteria.

“You two sound like you've been married for twenty years,” he said.

Alka looked offended. “I would never marry someone who takes this long to choose lunch.”

Dia nodded solemnly. “Finally, a reasonable boundary.”

Nikhil shook his head and returned to his laptop.

The girls kept arguing.

Neither noticed that, by then, they had stopped needing a reason to spend time together.

6. The Photograph

Near the end of the academic year, the university held an exhibition for student projects.

Alka presented a poster about her research work. Dia demonstrated a cybersecurity project involving the security of personal data.

Their projects had almost nothing in common.

Still, Alka came to Dia's presentation. She stood near the back, listening while Dia explained the system to a group of students who kept asking whether it could hack social media accounts.

Dia spotted her halfway through and nearly lost her train of thought.

Afterward, Alka said, “You were good.”

Dia packed her laptop into her bag. “I know.”

Alka laughed. “I'm complimenting you.”

“And I'm accepting it.”

“You're so annoying.”

“You came all this way to tell me that?”

“I came to make sure you weren't telling people you could hack Instagram.”

Dia smiled.

Later, Dia visited Alka's display and listened to her explain her research. She didn't understand every detail, but she asked questions because she wanted to know what Alka was excited about.

Alka noticed.

Afterward, they found Stephen and Luca near the entrance, arguing about where to eat. The four of them went out together.

They talked about the exhibition, complained about university, and took a photograph that nobody particularly liked.

Stephen blinked. Luca looked away. Dia was laughing at something Alka had said. Alka was looking at Dia instead of the camera.

It was a terrible photograph.

Alka saved it.

7. The Things That Remain Ordinary

University life continued.

There were exams, holidays, changes in schedules, new people, and weeks when neither girl had enough time to do anything beyond the work directly in front of her.

They didn't become inseparable. They didn't suddenly discover that they had identical dreams or that every difficult moment could be solved by a conversation.

Alka had her laboratory work, her own friendships, and her plans for what might come after graduation. Dia had projects, technical interviews to prepare for, and an increasing awareness that cybersecurity was a field in which learning never really ended.

Sometimes, they went several days without meeting. Sometimes, they spoke only through messages. Sometimes, they sat together for an entire afternoon and talked about absolutely nothing important.

And that was all right.

One evening, after a particularly long day, Alka messaged Dia.

Edi, are you on campus?

Leaving in ten minutes. Why?

Nothing. Wanted to ask you something.

Dia waited near the entrance.

Alka arrived carrying a notebook and looking slightly out of breath.

“What happened?”

“Nothing happened.”

“Then why did you make me wait?”

“I wanted to walk with you.”

Dia stared at her.

“You could have said that.”

“I just did.”

They started walking.

The sky was pale with the last light of the evening. A bus pulled away from the stop, leaving behind the smell of exhaust and the sound of someone calling after a friend.

They talked about their days. Alka described an experiment that had finally worked. Dia told her about a bug she had spent three hours fixing, only to discover that the solution was a single misplaced character.

Alka laughed. “Three hours?”

“Don't.”

“I respect your profession.”

“You absolutely do not.”

They reached the point where their paths separated.

Alka turned towards her bus stop. Dia continued towards the main road.

“See you tomorrow?” Alka called.

“Probably.”

“That's not a proper answer.”

“It's the only one you're getting.”

Alka shook her head, smiling, and walked away.

Dia watched her for a moment before turning back towards the road.

There was nothing special about the evening. No important realisation arrived. No music played in the background.

It was simply the end of another university day.

And yet, years later, Dia might remember it.

Not because it had changed anything.

Because it hadn't needed to.

Alka had been there. They had walked together. They had laughed about something stupid.

And for that small stretch of time, the day had belonged to both of them.

8. A Life With Your Name in It

Perhaps, in another version of the future, Dia and Alka would live in different cities.

Perhaps one would move abroad while the other stayed closer to home. Perhaps their careers would take them into worlds so different that they would sometimes struggle to understand the details of each other's days.

They would miss things. They would forget to reply. They would occasionally have to reschedule calls because one of them was working late and the other had an early morning.

Their friendship would change, because people change and lives expand.

But Dia liked to imagine that, years from now, she could still send Alka a photograph of something ridiculous and receive a reply that made her laugh.

That Alka could still tell her about a difficult day without feeling the need to explain every detail.

That they could meet after months apart and spend the first ten minutes discussing work, the next twenty complaining about life, and the rest arguing about where to eat.

Not because nothing had changed.

Because enough had remained familiar.

And perhaps, on some future evening, they would remember the university corridors, the unreliable Wi-Fi, the laboratory notebook, the terrible photograph, and the two boys who had wandered in and out of their days.

They would laugh about how little they had known when they first met. How neither had expected much from the other. How a simple question about a network had somehow led to years of conversations.

And perhaps Alka would say, “You know, you were actually quite rude when we first met.”

Dia would protest. “You asked me to fix your Wi-Fi!”

“And you threatened to sell my water bottle.”

“I was joking!”

“That's what they all say.”

Dia would laugh.

The years between them would grow smaller for a moment. And there would be something quietly beautiful about that — the way an ordinary conversation could carry a person back to a place they had once inhabited without knowing how much it would matter later.

Because perhaps friendship isn't always about finding someone who changes your life in an obvious way.

Sometimes, it is about finding someone whose presence becomes part of the life you are already building.

Someone who sees you becoming a little older, a little more certain in some ways, and a little more confused in others.

Someone who doesn't need to understand every part of your world to care about what happens in it.

Someone whose own world you learn to care about, too.

Dia studied the ways systems failed. Alka studied the ways living things responded to change.

Neither subject prepared them for the strange, ordinary work of friendship.

There was no syllabus for it. No final examination. No guarantee that they would always get everything right.

There were simply the conversations they chose to have, the small efforts they made, and the time they gave each other when they could.

And perhaps that was the loveliest thing about their story.

They hadn't found each other because the universe had promised them a friendship.

They had found each other because, one afternoon, one girl asked a question about Wi-Fi.

The other answered.

And then, over time, they kept answering each other in all the little ways that mattered.

Not perfectly.

Not forever promised.

Just honestly, for as long as life allowed.

Some people don't change your life all at once.

They become part of it quietly, until their name appears in so many ordinary memories that you cannot imagine those years without them.

And one day, you realise that the best thing about meeting them was never the way it began. It was everything that came after.

For Dia and Alka, in this universe. ■